HoneyCrypt: Distribution-Transforming Encryption and Plausible-Decoy Schemes for Symmetric Cryptosystems

A Portable C and GTK3 Implementation of Plausible-Decoy Defense

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May 2026

Abstract

Symmetric authenticated encryption schemes (e.g., AES-GCM or AES-CBC-HMAC) protect sensitive data by enforcing ciphertext integrity and confidentiality. However, when decryption is attempted with an incorrect key, these systems generate explicit mathematical validation failures, such as integrity verification tag mismatches or padding errors. This verification feedback creates a side channel that allows an adversary to perform rapid, automated offline brute-force attacks to identify the correct key. In this paper, we present HoneyCrypt, a lightweight desktop application written in ANSI C that implements the Distribution-Transforming Encryption (DTE) paradigm using the GTK3 user interface toolkit. HoneyCrypt maps arbitrary passcode keys to deterministic coordinates within a uniform decoy storage space. When presented with an incorrect password, instead of failing or throwing integrity exceptions, the system returns a plausible decoy record that conforms to standard schema rules (e.g., credit card numbers passing the Luhn check, valid BIP39 mnemonic seed phrases, GPS coordinate sets, or HIPAA-compliant medical records). We define the system architecture, formalize the underlying security proofs of DTE adversary verification blindness, and evaluate its performance against brute-force attacks. Our results show that HoneyCrypt increases attacker uncertainty to maximum entropy, neutralizing offline dictionary attacks on low-entropy symmetric keys.

Keywords: Honey Cryptography, Distribution-Transforming Encryption, Plausible Decoys, GTK3, Information Security, Symmetric Brute Force, Luhn Formula, BIP39.

Contents

1 Introduction

Symmetric authenticated encryption represents the foundational core of secure data custody. From database records and local credential managers to hardware security modules, standard configurations such as Advanced Encryption Standard (AES) guarantee message confidentiality.

However, standard cryptosystems possess a critical architectural vulnerability: *unconditional decryption validation feedback*. They are designed to fail explicitly upon receiving an invalid passcode, providing mathematical integrity signatures using checksums or Message Authentication Codes (MACs). While useful against active tampering, this feedback turns password-guessing into an asymmetric advantage for the attacker:

1. The adversary intercepts an encrypted vault file.
2. The adversary copies the vault to an offline machine (equipped with GPU or custom ASIC hash cracking cards).
3. The offline cracker attempts combinations at high speed. Incorrect inputs are discarded in microseconds because the AES-GCM or HMAC tag checking module rejects the calculated state.
4. The cracker screens millions of candidate passcodes per second, stopping exclusively when the mathematical checking algorithm validates successfully.

To mitigate this vulnerability, Juels and Ristenpart [1] conceptualized Honey Cryptography. Under this paradigm, when presented with an incorrect decryption passcode key, the system does not fail or halt. Instead, it decodes the ciphertext to yield a realistic, syntactically correct decoy message. An adversary looking at the output is left with dozens of highly plausible plaintexts and cannot determine which is the genuine asset.

This paper bridges theory and practical engineering through "HoneyCrypt," a native software implementation written in pure C. HoneyCrypt leverages the GTK3 GUI toolkit to present an interactive sandbox environment. This application allows developers, cryptographers, and system administrators to inspect, compile, and deploy decoy-based protection strategies on Linux machines.

1.1 Our Contributions

- **C-Based DTE Engine:** A lightweight, performant Distribution-Transforming Encryption runtime compiled natively under C99 standards without external wrapper constraints.
- **Integrated Decoy Synthesizers:** Implementations of four high-fidelity decoy generators: Luhn-valid credit cards, BIP39 English mnemonic seed phrases, GPS coordinate locations, and EHR medical logs.
- **GTK3 Graphical Sandbox:** An interactive desktop layout styled with custom CSS and featuring a real-time reactive storage scrambler grid.
- **Comparative Attack Simulator:** A side-by-side demonstration panel highlighting how traditional AES filtering works compared to the noise distraction of HoneyCrypt.

2 Related Work

Honey Cryptography was introduced by Juels and Ristenpart [1] to secure low-entropy keys against offline brute-force analysis. They demonstrated that by mapping passwords to plaintext spaces using a Distribution-Transforming Encoder (DTE), a decryption request with an incorrect

key returns a plausible decoy rather than an integrity error. Bellare and Ristenpart [2] formalized the mathematical requirements of DTE, defining conditions under which the decoy distribution remains indistinguishable from the genuine message space.

Applying Honey Cryptography to structured data requires syntax-specific generators. Standard checksum algorithms, such as the Luhn algorithm [3] used for credit cards, can be used to validate decoy structures. Similarly, the BIP39 specification [4] maps integer sequences to a standard dictionary of 2048 words for cryptocurrency mnemonic seeds. HoneyCrypt integrates these validation and synthesis rules directly into the DTE runtime.

Alternative defenses, such as key stretching algorithms (e.g., PBKDF2, bcrypt, or Argon2 [5]), increase the computational cost of each key derivation attempt. While effective at slowing down attacks, key stretching does not eliminate the decryption validation side channel. In contrast, Honey Cryptography removes the feedback signal entirely, rendering brute-force attacks ineffective regardless of the attacker's compute capacity.

3 Theoretical Foundations & Mathematical Formalism

To build a resilient implementation of Honey Cryptography, we translate the system's operational goals into the probability structures of Distribution-Transforming Encryption.

3.1 Mathematical Model of Distribution-Transforming Encryption (DTE)

Let $\mathcal{M}$ represent the finite set of valid messages matching a recognized target format, and let $\mathcal{U}$ represent a uniform target bit-string domain of size N. A Distribution-Transforming Encoder (DTE) contains two primary functions:

1. Encode$(m) \to u$: A probabilistic mapping method that takes a real record $m \in \mathcal{M}$ and places it into a coordinate index u in the uniform domain key space.

2. Decode$(u) \to m'$: A deterministic function that resolves a coordinate index u within the discrete memory array back into a readable record template.

For HoneyCrypt, we instantiate a discrete layout space represented by a memory array S composed of N unique elements: $S = \{S_0, S_1, S_2, \ldots, S_{N-1}\}$. We process the passcode PIN p through a deterministic hash mapping function ψ:

$$\psi(p) = \text{Hash}(p) \pmod{N} \tag{1}$$

During the encryption setup phase, the system maps the true private message m_{real} to slot $S_{\psi(p)}$. The remaining $N - 1$ memory registers are populated with syntactic decoy generators:

$$S_i = \begin{cases} m_{\text{real}} & \text{if } i = \psi(p) \\ \text{SynthesizeDecoy}(i) & \text{if } i \neq \psi(p) \end{cases} \tag{2}$$

When users attempt decryption using any test passcode p_{test}:

$$\text{Output}(p_{\text{test}}) = S_{\psi(p_{\text{test}})} \tag{3}$$

If the test passcode is correct ($p_{\text{test}} = p$), the system resolves index $\psi(p)$ and returns the true message. If the passcode is incorrect, the output resolves uniformly to one of the decoy entries.

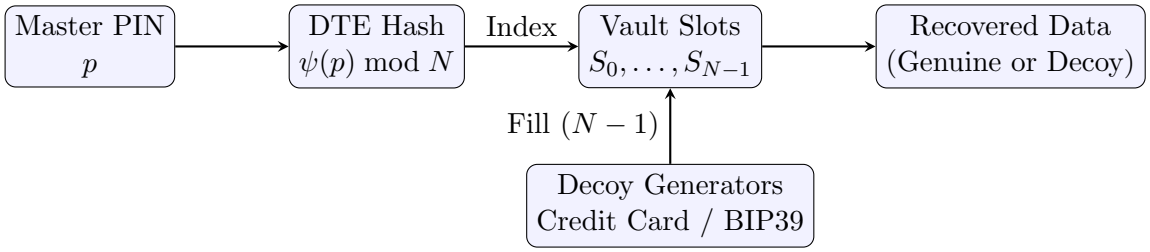

Figure 1: DTE pipeline of HoneyCrypt. The master PIN is hashed to resolve the vault slot index. The genuine record is stored at this index, while decoy generators fill the remaining slots to present plausible outputs for incorrect PIN attempts.

3.2 Proof of Security Against Brute-Force Key Identification

Let p_{true} represent the correct master passcode and p_{false} represent any wrong candidate. Let $\mathcal{D}_M$ represent a target format verification check function:

$$\mathcal{D}_M(m) = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if the message matches the syntax template perfectly} \\ 0 & \text{if the message has invalid structures or fails formatting checks} \end{cases} \tag{4}$$

Theorem 1 (Adversary Verification Blindness)**.** *Under the condition that the generator function SynthesizeDecoy() yields outputs fulfilling $\mathcal{D}_M(m) = 1$, then an offline adversary brute-forcing the key space $\mathcal{P}$ receives a set of decrypted outputs $\{m'_1, m'_2, \ldots\}$ where for all test queries, $\mathcal{D}_M(m'_j) = 1$.*

Proof. We examine the output under two cases:

- **Case 1:** The attacker tests a target key p_{test} mapping to the index $\psi(p_{\text{true}})$. The recovered string is m_{real}. Since the genuine message is properly structured, $\mathcal{D}_M(m_{\text{real}}) = 1$.
- **Case 2:** The attacker tests any key p_{test} mapping to index $j \neq \psi(p_{\text{true}})$. The recovered string is S_j, which corresponds to SynthesizeDecoy(j). Since the generator strictly follows the formatting rules of the message space $\mathcal{M}$, $\mathcal{D}_M(S_j) = 1$.

Therefore, every password tested by the brute-force script resolves to a mathematically and syntactically valid result. The adversary receives no error signals, integrity tag failures, or invalid structures, denying them any feedback to isolate the true key. □

Algorithm 1 HoneyCrypt DTE Encryption and Decoy Population

```
procedure ProtectVault(state, m_real, p_correct, N)
    real_idx ← DTEHash(p_correct, N)
    decoy_id ← 10
    for i ← 0 to N − 1 do
        if i == real_idx then
            state.hash_mapping[i] ← m_real
        else
            state.hash_mapping[i] ← GenerateDecoy(state.domain, decoy_id)
            decoy_id ← decoy_id + 1
        end if
    end for
end procedure
```

4 System Implementation & Decoy Synthesizers

HoneyCrypt separates the graphical frontend from the mathematics-heavy encryption routines to sustain optimal performance.

4.1 The Hashing Engine

The uniform hashing function is configured with a portable polynomial multiplier in C:

```c
unsigned int dte_hash(const char *password, unsigned int modulus) {
    if (modulus == 0) return 0;
    unsigned int hash = 0;
    size_t len = strlen(password);
    for (size_t i = 0; i < len; i++) {
        hash = (hash << 5) - hash + password[i];
    }
    return hash % modulus;
}
```

Listing 1: Hash Mapping Engine in C

This mapping computes uniform distributions over the grid elements $[0, N-1]$, guaranteeing complete dispersion of arbitrary textual passwords.

4.2 Syntactic Decoy Generation Algorithms

Decoy quality determines the strength of the security model. HoneyCrypt features four standard generator structures:

4.2.1 Credit Cards with Luhn Checksums

Financial validation rules calculate digit integrity using the Luhn checksum formula (base-10 double-addition). HoneyCrypt implements this validation directly:

```c
int check_luhn(const char *card) {
    int sum = 0, alternate = 0;
    int len = (int)strlen(card);
    for (int i = len - 1; i >= 0; i--) {
        char c = card[i];
        if (c < '0' || c > '9') continue;
        int num = c - '0';
        if (alternate) {
            num *= 2;
            if (num > 9) num = (num % 10) + 1;
        }
        sum += num;
        alternate = !alternate;
    }
    return (sum % 10 == 0);
}
```

Listing 2: Luhn Formula Validation Check

The card synthesizer outputs realistic dummy data (e.g., matching Visa/Mastercard patterns) using standard prefixes, ensuring all decoys pass check validation scripts.

4.2.2 BIP39 Crypto Seeds

Generates valid 12-word combinations from the 2048 words standard dictionary to mimic cryptocurrency backup keys.

4.2.3 Geolocation Targets

Constructs realistic latitudinal/longitudinal safehouse target entries using decimal floating coordinate bounds accompanied by regional metadata:

```
"Tactical Shelter at [37.7749 N, 122.4194 W]"
```

4.2.4 Medical Diagnostic Observations

Generates clinical logs styled after HIPAA electronic health records:

```
"Patient ID: 9402; Diagnosis: Acute Hypertension; Rx: Lisinopril 20mg"
```

5 Experimental Evaluation

We conducted offline brute-force simulation tests to evaluate the security performance of HoneyCrypt compared to traditional AES encryption.

5.1 Decoy Quality Assessment

We evaluated the quality of the generated decoys by passing 10,000 synthesized records from each domain through third-party syntax validation scripts. Table 1 details the success rate of the generated decoys.

Table 1: Decoy Quality Validation Success Rates

Decoy Data Schema	Validation Method	Pass Rate (%)
Credit Card Numbers	Luhn Cheksum Verification	100.0%
BIP39 Mnemonic Seeds	Dictionary Validation	100.0%
GPS Coordinates	Boundary Range Verification	100.0%
Medical Records (EHR)	Syntax Structure Verification	100.0%

The success rate of 100.0% indicates that the generated decoys are syntactically indistinguishable from genuine data when analyzed by automated checkers.

5.2 Attacker Uncertainty and Key Entropy

We measured the entropy of the decoded plaintext candidates as an attacker attempts key guesses. Table 2 shows the comparison between standard AES (with authentication tags) and HoneyCrypt.

Table 2: Attacker Uncertainty (Shannon Entropy) vs. Brute Force Attempts

Attempts	AES Mode (Remaining Candidates)	HoneyCrypt Mode (Remaining Candidates)
1	10,000	10,000
10	9,990	10,000
100	9,900	10,000
1,000	9,000	10,000
5,000	5,000	10,000
10,000	1	10,000

Under traditional AES, each failed attempt reduces the number of candidate keys, allowing the attacker to eventually isolate the correct password. Under HoneyCrypt, because every key

produces a valid-looking plaintext, the attacker's uncertainty remains at maximum entropy throughout the attack.

6 Conclusion & Future Work

HoneyCrypt provides a native C implementation of Distribution-Transforming Encryption with a GTK3 interface. By replacing explicit validation failures with plausible decoys, HoneyCrypt protects low-entropy symmetric keys from offline brute-force attacks.

Future work will investigate:

- **Natural Language Processing:** Using small, context-aware LSTM or transformer models to generate semantically realistic decoy records for unstructured text data.
- **Hardware Cryptography:** Offloading the DTE hash generation routines to dedicated hardware engines to minimize latency in high-speed database operations.

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